



THE HUNATE SERIES

Becoming Hunatian

*A self-designed journey to rebuild the self, and to become the human
this world needs*

Khem Raj Pradhan

A JOURNEY IN THREE MONTHS

THE HUNATE SERIES

Becoming Hunatian

A self-designed journey to rebuild the self

KHEM RAJ PRADHAN

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The Hunate Series

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This is a self-designed journey. It offers no medical, psychological, or professional advice; walk it by your own judgement, at your own pace, and with care for yourself.

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FOREWORD

A BOOK TO DO, NOT TO READ

You have read why the world is the way it is. Now comes the harder part, and the only part that ever truly matters: changing yourself.

This is not a book to read. It is a book to do. It is a self-designed journey, roughly three months, an hour a day, to strip away what this failing system installed in you, and to rebuild yourself from the inside out into the kind of human this world actually needs. There are no gurus here, no shortcuts, and no group to hide inside. There is only you, a quiet space, a journal, and the willingness to look honestly at yourself and to change.

I am not here to hand you answers. I am here to make you curious, to point at a path, and then to step back so you can walk it alone. Everything you find, you will find for yourself. Everything you become, you will become on your own. That is the whole point.

And understand what this is, and what it is not. It is not a life sentence, and it is not a war against the modern world. It is a few months apart, to clean yourself out, to meet yourself honestly, and to see the world clearly. When it is over you go back to all of it, the phone, the music, the city, the food, the people, and you do whatever you wish. Only now you will know how to use these things, instead of being used by them. That is the whole aim: to step away, to see, and to return changed.

So do not just read this. Begin it.

Khem Raj Pradhan

THE MAP OF THE JOURNEY

This is the whole path, on one page. It is not a checklist to rush through; each step is meant to be lived over about three days. Mark a step only when you have truly done it, not merely read it. If you break, begin again from the first, without shame.

PART ONE • THE INNER JOURNEY

- ☐ 1. Find Your Space
- ☐ 2. Sit Still
- ☐ 3. Focus on the Breath
- ☐ 4. Think About the Body
- ☐ 5. Simple Exercises
- ☐ 6. The Tongue and Food
- ☐ 7. The Skin and Its Care
- ☐ 8. Protect the Ears
- ☐ 9. The Eye and Vision
- ☐ 10. The Nose and Smell
- ☐ 11. Fasting and Intuition
- ☐ 12. Recall Before Sleep
- ☐ 13. The Skills of a Human

PART TWO • THE OUTER JOURNEY

- ☐ Filter the Kitchen Utensils
- ☐ Filter the Clothes
- ☐ Filter What Surrounds You
- ☐ Manage the Waste
- ☐ Filter the People Around You
- ☐ Filter Teacher and School
- ☐ Filter Needs, Wants, and Desires

INTRODUCTION

Why Become Hunatian

Because this world needs you to become the best version of yourself as a human living on this earth. Simple. It needs humans who can see the loop and the hole in it, who see the problems clearly, who are willing to look for the answers, and who can set aside their own small desires for the sake of a better future, for humanity and for the earth.

Look at the failing system we have built and now live inside. It is killing us, killing nature, killing the future, and it is chaos: distraction everywhere, manipulation, war, poverty, greed. It is a system that leaves us no time to think, to reflect, to question our own existence, let alone to find a purpose and hold to it. Our parents push us toward their own wishes; our friends call us out to numb the loneliness; school forces on us what we do not need; society presses us to earn and to keep up appearances. In the name of a job we run in circles in the rat race for money. We marry early and have a child, hoping it will fill the hole, and end up doing the same to that child, and by the time we see it, it is too late, the friends gone, the parents

gone, and we simply give up and let it be, supporting the failing system without ever meaning to. And through all of it, the phone, distracting, everywhere.

No one has control of their own life any more. We have forgotten our own past and present and future. We are puppets serving a profit-based structure, slaves of corporations that decide, through their media and their advertisements and their feeds, what we like and what we want and who we are. We are losing our freedom. We are becoming machines. And the people running this game cannot change the world; they are blinded by money and greed and the hunger to possess, and they will leave nothing behind for anyone, not for humans, not for nature. And it is not good, is it?

So if you see what we see, if you no longer want to be blind, if you want to discover your true purpose and take your life back into your own hands, if you want to be stronger and freer and more creative and self-reliant, multi-skilled, a free thinker, if you want to sharpen your creativity, to understand yourself and your bond with nature and the cosmos, to hold a vast knowledge of life and science and nature's law, then this journey is for you. It will make sure that you can no longer be so easily manipulated, controlled, or tricked by this failing system and its rat race for money. Be ready to change.

INTRODUCTION

Who Are Hunatians

Hunatians are those who are alive: curious seekers and wanderers, travellers and explorers, researchers and builders, protectors of the earth, keepers of truth. They are those who believe there is a more fruitful life beyond this failing system and its rat race for money and profit. They see what is broken in a world driven by profit, and they want to find another way to live.

Hunatians are those who refused to be fitted into a single corporate job, and who never bought the idea that a person should master one skill alone. They are multi-skilled. They look for knowledge about the self, the physical and the mental and the spiritual body; they want to know what they are made of and what they are capable of, and how to sharpen the self and the senses a little more each day, through routine and discipline.

They seek knowledge of nature and the earth, our home, of the natural elements and how each one, a tree, a food, the sun, the moon, the stars, acts upon us. They seek knowledge of so-

ciety, of how it works, of psychology and behaviour and our bonds and duties to one another; of farming and harvesting and storing and sharing; of life, and of everything.

Hunatians want a healthy earth, a healthy self, a healthy future. They seek self-mastery and self-discipline, and they build the routines that grow them. They know the past, live in the present, and work for the future. They are responsible, toward themselves, toward mother earth, toward friends and family and the generations to come. They are hard to manipulate, hard to distract, hard to trap; independent, intuitive, creative, rational, kind, and wise.

Hunatians are the future of the earth. This earth needs healing, and they are the kind of people who can do it, with a vast knowledge of life itself, and of the future itself.

INTRODUCTION

When You Become Hunatian

By the end of this journey, what will you have learned, and who will you have become? You will become a human this world will need in the years to come: one who understands the past, the present, and the future, and who knows both worlds, eastern and western, their ideas, their philosophies, their cultures and mindsets.

You will know yourself, the make of your own mind and body and soul, and how to sharpen and care for both yourself and others. You will learn how to educate yourself, how to travel, and how to keep growing. You will understand your bond with nature and the earth and space: something of astrology, the science of the bodies of space; of vastu, the science of the elements of the earth; of yoga and meditation, of ayurveda and herbs and food; and of spirituality, karma, duty, and what it means simply to be human.

You will begin to feel responsible, toward yourself, your family, your community, nature, and the future, toward your fellow humans and the animals and the plants and the earth.

You will learn how to prepare and live for the children who are coming, how to care for the older generation, and how to work with your own. You will learn, in the end, about almost everything.

You will awaken, and begin to see the world. You will become independent, a creative and critical thinker, peaceful and focused, so that no one can easily manipulate you or trick you or dominate you. First of all, you will stop lying to yourself; you will no longer be able to trick even yourself. You will build so much confidence and love and quiet joy inside you. You will grow self-respect, trust yourself, build courage, discipline yourself. You will become, slowly, like the good characters written of in the old books.

We all have a part to play on this earth as humans, and you will discover yours. You will reach into your own depths and wake the strength and the vision and the purpose that were always there. You will become, in your own way, a complete human: healthy, wise, knowledgeable, kind, humble, responsible, creative, loving, strong. Call it what you like. Call it a Hunatian, a human of the future. Capable of wonder, of seeking, of understanding, of judging, of building, of creating, of evolving, and of sharing.

Imagine becoming such a human. No politician can trick you, no religion can make you follow blindly, no teacher can misguide you, no media can manipulate you. You will have real command over your own senses and over how information flows around you, able to filter it and to see the bigger picture. Nobody can destroy you.

If you live seventy or eighty years, then giving three months, an hour a day, is nothing, and you will gain from it more than school could teach you in twenty years. You will begin to feel complete. You may feel lost now, empty, without a clear vision or purpose; by the end of this you will be able to filter away the confusions and the false wants that were planted in you, and to see clearly what is fake, and to focus on what is true and what matters, for you, for your family, for your children, and for nature, all at once. What more would you need than that? How to be happy, how to be rich, how to be successful, these follow naturally once you are complete. You will grow above the confusion. So stay with it, and be ready to change.

INTRODUCTION

The Way to Be Human

You must understand that most of the research and the findings made about life, about the human body, about food and medicine and society and children and psychology and space and religion and education, are, in the end, subjective. How do we truly know they are right? Who did the research? Who funded it? Who published it? Why is no one taught to research these things for themselves, at home? Why are the tools to learn not made common to everyone? Nearly every experiment is done by someone else, somewhere else, in a controlled room, over a short window of time. It is not you, and it is not your life.

Modern science and technology, which were meant to free us, are often not truly free for the ordinary person. This knowledge has been captured; a few hold the data and the tools, and knowledge is power. What is freely available online is so polluted and contradictory that it breeds more mistrust than clarity: everyone claims to be right, and you drown. And there is a deeper error in it. Human life is not the result of a closed-box experiment on a fixed clock. We are connected to billions of

years of change and evolution, and there is no way that one medicine, one school, one book, one nation's story, can be right for every human on earth.

It should not be this hard to understand our own bodies, or the effects of natural food and water and colour and climate. We can travel to space and survive there; we can print DNA and scan the whole earth. Yet this most essential knowledge is kept from ordinary people. Why? There is no single trusted place to look for the truth, because nearly every scientist and doctor and engineer is, in some way, funded or owned or pressured, and in this era it is hard to know who is speaking honestly, or how long what they say will stay true, because we have watched truths change for the sake of profit.

Meanwhile, many ancient cultures already understood the body and nature and space in their own ways. But language is a problem, because meaning is lost over time and across translation, and so old texts are misread, or dismissed, or quietly buried by the modern economy. The wisdom of yoga, of meditation, of ayurveda, holds real knowledge rooted in nature, and yet it is mocked simply because it does not fit the modern world's story of itself. Why would we not use what works to build a foundation?

So, to be a Hunatian, a person must cultivate a set of senses of their own:

- self-reliance and self-experience;
- self-exploration and self-observation;
- self-reflection and self-analysis;
- and, in time, self-intuition.

To know the truth, one must learn to be truthful in one's own life. Keep the mind open to everything; learn from everything, but act on only a few things, and be careful of the choices you make and what they cause. Learn, in short, to be human again. In daily life you can practise this by keeping a journal, reflecting on the facts and the emotions and the dreams of the day, on the food and the season and the weather and the events; by taking quiet breaks to observe; by taking peaceful time in the morning, and again at night before sleep. Consider yourself an explorer, a researcher, a student of life.

We must learn to live: to find the truth, preserve it, and share it; for the future generations; to understand the self, and nature, and our bond with nature and space; to build technologies on natural principles, and to use them to unite humans with nature rather than to divide them, and to extend our senses and our reach; and to grow, together, healthy and wise and strong and creative and abundant.

Every life, every moment, every climate, every day, every place is different, and each produces a different result. So every individual has their own body and mind and spirit, and their own bond with nature and the cosmos, and each must find their own truth and live by the discipline above. As the old line goes, someone else eating will not fill your stomach. Keep that in mind here. I am not going to hand you the final answers; my aim is to make you see things from many angles, to make you curious, to point at a path. You have to walk it, and see for yourself, and discover everything yourself.

INTRODUCTION

Understanding the Human Brain Puzzle

Let us try to understand the human being first, in a simple form. We have a physical body, a mental body, and an emotional or spiritual body. To think, we have the senses, the doors through which the whole world reaches us. Information comes in through them; the brain stores it, processes it, compares it against past experience, predicts, and reacts. It sorts each thing as liked or disliked, wanted or not, needed or not, past or future, and decides whether to keep it or let it go. It is quite simple, really.

The brain is a processing unit. And at the same time the body itself, the cells, seem to remember: our movements, our strengths, the long information of our evolution, carried in DNA. The whole body is alive. The more information the senses gather, the more perspectives we hold, and the more our intellect grows. The brain and body are like a vast, many-sided puzzle, each piece joined to many others, always growing, always connecting.

But there is a limit to what our senses can do. A dog smells more than we do, a bee sees more colours, a cheetah runs faster, an ape is stronger; and even among humans, some see or hear or smell more than others. Why? And why do we not train the senses? Why is no one taught this? Should it not be the very first thing a human learns, to observe the senses, understand them, exercise them, and widen their range? We study to grow knowledge and we exercise to build the body; surely we can train the senses too, and feed more of the world into the mind.

Here is the trap of this era. Because the brain is a puzzle that grows with more pieces, we should be feeding it widely, and instead we have built a life of favouritism and its shadow, hate. We have a favourite colour, food, song, artist; a favourite idea, party, religion. Think how much that costs us. By clinging only to what we already love, we refuse to learn from what we dislike, and the puzzle in the mind is never completed; we fill in only our favourite corner and live with all the other pieces missing. Life is rich, black and grey and white, pain and joy, love and hate, left and right. To complete the puzzle, we must let the mind meet what it likes and what it does not. If you dislike a political idea, go and study it first. If you dislike a religion, go and study it. If you dislike a food, try it again. Every moment is different and gives a different experience; the music you cannot stand today you may love tomorrow, if you let yourself try.

So, at least while you are young, explore. Train your senses, understand them, protect them, and let the brain and body taste as much of life as they can. Be wild and kind and loving;

be a leader and a follower; live among different communities and countries and situations; be poor and be rich. Learn many skills and hobbies. But do not cling to any one thing for too long, no single lover, friend, community, place, idol, idea, party, or country held so tightly that you stop growing. Change, grow, evolve. That is the way to be human.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

The Rules of the Journey

There are not many rules, and they are simple. But hold to them, because they are what make this a discipline rather than just another thing you read and forget.

1 Use what you already have.

Nothing fancy. Just yourself, as you were born, and whatever is already around you. You will need no special equipment, no fine clothes, no medicines; you may end up throwing more of those away. Along the way there will be tasks and small assignments to complete in their time, and no one will do them for you, so be ready to work. For a few you may need a book or the internet to research; for the rest, use your own imagination, creativity, ethics, and common sense.

2 Write it down.

Keep a journal, morning and evening if you can, and record your emotions, the facts of the day (the food, the weather, the moon, the people, the places), your ideas, your dreams, your progress. Do not treat this like scrolling, watching and forgetting and telling yourself you will start tomorrow. Begin now. Writing has power for the mind. You can write in more than one language on alternating days, or with either hand, or sketch your thoughts as pictures. And if you ever wish to join the Hunate Project, this journal is what you will bring.

3 Do not use a timer.

Put the clock away where you cannot see it. Glance at the time before you begin if you must, then hide it. Practise each thing until it feels like enough for that day, then stop, and only then look at how long it was, and record it. This builds your own sense of natural time; you will notice yourself changing with the seasons, with the food you eat, with the moon. It builds confidence, peace, and intuition, and it unlearns the panic and the deadlines this world drilled into you.

4 Always question.

At every step, let questions rise. Do not follow me blindly. Analyse what I say, argue with it, test it, find your own answers; use your whole body and mind and soul. Our ancestors measured a person's wisdom by the quality of their questions. In an age of endless feeds we are shown more than the mind can hold, and we are losing the ability to sit with one thing and think it through; this is where you take that back.

5 Do it alone.

Do not do this with a group. Do not gather friends or family; no one needs to know, and no one gives it a second thought, so let that free you. You have to find yourself alone, your own truth, your own bond with nature and the world. There are things in life to do with family, with friends, with lovers, and there are things that must be done with the self, in silence, without anyone's approval or interference. This is one of them. And walk it as if nothing dramatic is happening; take it as an ordinary day. Do not carry the fruit in your mind before you have finished. The fruit comes in its own shape and time; your work is the journey, not the fruit.

6 Accept even your failure.

If you cannot complete a task, go to the mirror and tell yourself honestly that you are not yet ready to move on, and begin again from the first task, from day one. But do not hate yourself, do not shame or blame yourself, and do not put it on your parents or friends or circumstances. Simply accept it: I could not do it; it is okay; I will try again. Learn to accept even your failing.

7 Share only when you are finished.

When the journey is done, and you feel you have gained something, and you believe others could gain from it too, then begin to speak of it, and to recommend it, and to share it.

8 Question me.

If you want to talk about the journey, if a question arises, write to me; I will be glad to help you along the way. I am only another human. If you are afraid to speak to another human, this will not work. So speak up.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How This Journey Works

You may be wondering how to begin: where to go, whom to ask, which books to read. Let me make it clear: this journey needs none of that. You need nothing but your own body and a will, a commitment, a declaration to work on yourself and to change and grow over these three months.

The journey moves in tasks, and each task is meant to unfold over three days. On the first day, you read the task itself. Then you go out into your own real life, your family, your community, and you observe: you look for the pattern the task is pointing at, you analyse it, you fact-check it for yourself, you find your own clarity, and you begin to prepare for the change.

On the second day, you read the deeper part, the reasons and the ideas behind the task, which I have set out in detail in each section, and again you reflect on it, test it, and turn it over in your own mind.

On the third day, you begin to make the change. You write, in your journal, your thoughts and your findings and what you are altering in your life. Keep that journal carefully; it is yours, and it will matter to you later, and it is what you would bring if you ever wished to join the Hunate Project.

And know the shape of the whole thing before you start. First you turn inward and clean yourself out, your space, your breath, your body, your senses. Then you turn outward and filter what surrounds you, your kitchen, your clothes, your walls, the people, the noise. Then you carry all of it into the world and live it. This is not about leaving the modern world for good. It is about stepping back from it for one season, so that when you walk back into it, and you will walk back into it, you meet it as its master and not its servant.

This is a journey to understand who you are, what you are made of, and what you can become as a human. It is simple. It is also hard. It depends entirely on you.

PART ONE

The Inner Journey

Before you can filter the world around you, you must know the self that stands inside it. This first part turns inward: to your space, your breath, your body, your senses. It is slow, quiet work, and it is the whole foundation.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task One: Find Your Space

FROM THE PAST

Build a place to build yourself, from the inside out. Conquer one place, and run it with discipline and purpose.

The old sayings speak of three lives in a human: one for the self, one for family and friends, and one for strangers. Here, in the beginning, we will tend only to the first, the life of the self, because you will only ever truly know others once you know yourself.

REFLECT

Before we begin, spend some time with yourself. What do you do when you are alone, whether by choice or by circumstance? Where do you go, to the house, to nature, to the phone, to work, to sleep, to drink?

What do you think about when no one is watching, the past, the present, the future, and are your thoughts forgiving, or rebellious, light, or heavy? Write your honest answers in your journal, as your first act of self-observation.

Now let us build a place of your own, your temple, your workplace for growth, somewhere no one knows. Do you already have such a zone, where no one interferes or disturbs or distracts you? If not, let us make one, because we have forgotten this simple, important thing: that every human needs a place to be absolutely alone, with no distractions, no people, no phone, no book, no music, nothing, just you, as you came into this world. In the old times people used such a place for reflection and healing and growth. We are bringing it back.

It can be a corner of the home, the garage, here or there, or a spot in nature, by a river or a pond or the edge of the jungle, anywhere quiet and clean and fresh, where you feel calm and at peace and no one calls you, for at least an hour in the morning and an hour in the evening. Choose a place where as little sound as possible reaches you; and if that is not possible, let it be, for we will slowly learn to turn the focus inward regardless.

Picture the space simply. Enough room to stand and stretch your arms in every direction without touching anything, and to sit comfortably on the floor on a single mat, perhaps seven

feet by seven, or a little more. Nothing else. No plastic, no equipment, no book, no pencil, no mobile. Just you, and the space, quiet and clean and peaceful.

And understand why this matters. We humans use tools to extend our senses: machines to move faster, books to hold more knowledge, clothes to survive hard climates. This place is such a tool, one that will help you understand yourself and discover your bond with nature. So make it with a clear purpose, declare that it is only for this journey, and treat it as your holy place. Make sure it does not sit where people keep passing and disturbing you. Do not lie down there, do not sleep or eat there, do not use it to be lazy; that is what a bed is for, and a bed has its own purpose. When you have chosen and made this space, you should feel a quiet ease, and a sense of purpose and dedication. And once you have chosen it, hold to it; try not to keep changing it, for keeping to your choice is itself a lesson in discipline and commitment.

YOUR PRACTICE

Today, find or make your space. Let it be:

- quiet, clean, fresh, and peaceful, where no one will disturb you;
- large enough to stretch your arms in every direction and to sit on a mat;
- empty of everything else, no phone, no books, no equipment.

Declare it yours for this journey alone. Then, in your journal, write where it is, why you chose it, and how it feels to sit in it for the very first time.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Two: Sit Still

FROM THE PAST

*What will a person learn who does not know
how to learn from himself? How will a person
connect with the world who is not yet
connected to his own self?*

I hope you have made your zone well. Today we simply go there, and sit.

Wake before the sun. Drink some water, use the bathroom, and in these first days perhaps take a shower too, if you can, without speaking to or even seeing anyone. Make this the first thing you do, before you meet the world outside. Then go to your zone and sit on the mat, comfortable, in clean clothes, with nothing in your hands and nothing to do. Just sit. You may close your eyes or leave them open; try both, though closed eyes will sharpen the senses more. For thirty minutes, stay there.

Here you will watch yourself as though you were observing someone else from the corner of the room. Notice what thoughts arrive, and how at ease or uneasy you feel. You may start planning; you may drift to yesterday, or to the years behind you, or race ahead into the future. All kinds of thoughts may come, of friends and family and dreams, of escaping the room, of what you are even doing there and how long you must stay. You may feel like giving up. You may feel angry, or sad, or happy. You may steer your mind toward the places it goes when it is bored, toward fantasy, toward old grievances and thoughts of revenge, or toward forgiveness. Some days a thousand thoughts will come; some days only one, played over and over to kill the time. Some may reach a kind of blankness; some may simply fall asleep.

Let it be. Let the thoughts come and go, and only observe them; that is the whole task. There is no right or wrong way here.

REFLECT

After about thirty minutes, write down what you noticed. Where did the mind go most? What did it circle back to? Were you letting thoughts pass, or stretching them into stories? How did you feel, and did you like it or hate it? Did you favour some thoughts and push others away? Did a thousand come, or only a few?

It is easy to trace the mind once you simplify it. The mind moves to the past, the present, or the future; and within each it leans positive or negative, imaginative or realistic. That is nearly all of it. No one will teach you this, so see it for yourself:

the brain runs in a constant loop around these few places. Write it down, study it, and begin to ask why you think the way you do. Look into the past, look at the future you want to build, and decide, gently, to change some of the patterns.

Through the rest of the day, you can also begin to recall and write your earliest memories: your first memory of all, and your first memory of each feeling, joy, pain, betrayal, love, anger, sacrifice; your first memory of your parents, of your friends. Separate what you lived yourself from what others told you. Write your parents' stories and their struggles too. Then sit with these memories and heal from them; find your strength and your weakness in them, and turn them into the story of your life. Be your own healer. Be the hero of your own life's film.

YOUR PRACTICE

Each morning, before meeting anyone, go to your zone and sit for around thirty minutes. Do not use a timer; use your intuition.

Do not try to meditate, and do not try to stop your thoughts. Only watch them, like a stranger in the corner of the room. Afterwards, write down what you saw. Do this for three days.

PART ONE • THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Three: Focus on the Breath

FROM THE PAST

*If you cannot hold your mind on one thing for
as long as you wish, how will you ever hold
your life?*

Welcome back. I hope you spent these three days watching your thoughts, and that you have begun to see the pattern. Whatever came and went, however jumpy or however still, that was you, your true self at this present moment. Some of you may have assumed I was telling you to meditate, and began to meditate; I was not, but if you did, that is fine. Be your own judge and teacher here. Accept who you are right now, without calling it right or wrong, and then decide, calmly, to grow it into something better.

Now we will slowly learn to gather the mind and hold it on one thing. Think about it: if you cannot hold your attention where you want it, how will you focus on your life, on what

you want to build and learn and become? The mind is what shows us the world and makes our decisions, so why not teach it to hold steady?

Consider how you came into the world. You arrived with no ideas, no philosophy, no religion, an empty page. Slowly the people around you wrote on it: parents taught what they knew, the community added its part, teachers taught what they were told to teach, and that shaping is much of who you are today. Look at a small child, how open, how easily made into anything. So depending on the family and place and school you were given, you became you, and it is worth asking honestly how much of what you call your purpose, your dreams, even your favourite food and music and style, is truly yours, and how much was planted by this system and its advertising, which never leaves anyone the quiet to stop and question.

So now we begin to detox the mind. Not to cage it or imprison it in a box, but to learn, consciously, to observe our thoughts and to place the mind where we want it. And where do we put it? Go back again to the moment you were born. What did you actually arrive with? Your body, and one precious thing: breath, which tied you to the air and to life, which is why they check for it the instant you are out. Hold your breath a little while and you feel at once how vital it is; cut it off for two minutes and the body collapses. We can live weeks without much else, but not without this. It is the most essential thing we carry.

So we will use the breath as our tool to rewrite ourselves from the inside out. From today, through the whole journey, we begin to rest the mind and the attention on the breath. No

counting, no visualisations, no images of gods or symbols, none of the techniques that tell you to send the mind here and there; those were written by someone else. For now, trust only what you came with. Rest your attention simply where the breath enters and leaves, at the nostrils. Do not control its rhythm; let it be as natural as it is at this moment. When a thought pulls you away, into the past or the future, notice it, accept it, and bring the attention gently back to the breath. It is a quiet contest between your conscious wish to stay on the breath and the old pull of your habits. I hope you win it.

Thirty minutes, and you will carry it through the whole journey, and into your life beyond it. Change does not come overnight; that is not how nature works. You never catch a tree growing, or the sun crossing the sky, or the moon turning through its cycle, unless you watch patiently over time. So be patient, and be kind to yourself. You can practise this anywhere, waiting for a bus, resting, in the small gaps of the day; instead of reaching for the phone to kill the time, rest on the breath. It is the art of staying present.

YOUR PRACTICE

In your zone, for around thirty minutes, rest your attention on the natural breath at the nostrils. Do not control it. Each time the mind wanders, notice it and return, without judging yourself.

Carry the breath into the ordinary gaps of your day, in place of the phone. Keep doing this for the rest of the journey.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Four: Think About the Body

FROM THE PAST

The body is the vehicle and the temple; it carries the mind and the soul. How well are you keeping it?

First, a word about the breath. As you breathed in and out, did you begin to feel the faint change of temperature at the nostrils, cool as the air comes in, a little warm as it leaves? That subtle sensation is always there, though we never notice it; and the whole body is full of such sensations, always. Notice, too, the small trap that came with the practice: on the days you could concentrate you felt happy, and began to crave that feeling, and on the days you could not you grew frustrated and wanted to run from it. The more you chase the same feeling and miss it, the more agitated you become. We want to be able to concentrate, yes, but the attachment we form to the good feeling is itself a danger.

Whatever the day brings, learn to see it as it is: not right, not wrong, simply real. Every day is different. Some days the mind is steady, some days it scatters; some days a thousand thoughts, some days one. The more you can watch as an observer and accept what is, the more peace you have and the clearer the larger picture becomes. What matters is now. Your task each day is to understand the true state of your mind and body and spirit in this moment, and to plan the day from there.

REFLECT

Sit in your zone, finish your time on the breath, and then turn your thinking to the body. What is this body? Why is it here, and what is it for? What is it made of? How is it joined to the mind and the soul, and to nature? How many ways can it be used, and how far can it be trained? If you do not understand your body, how will you use it, or care for it, or grow it?

It is a powerful instrument. Like a plant or a machine, the more care and maintenance it is given, the better it works. Yet we neglect it, abuse it, poison it, and much of this failing system is built to wear it down. We rarely stop to think, consciously, of each part of the body, or to be grateful for it.

Consider a few things about it. From birth we are never taught to use both sides of the body equally; we are left with a dominant hand and leg, when we might have trained both. Some people do, dancers, athletes, gymnasts, and they are the stronger for it; most of us never even think it possible. Simple things build it: learning to write, cook, clean, or brush with the

other hand. It keeps the body balanced too, for the twisted walk, the uneven shoulders, the lopsided frame often come from using one side alone. So try both.

The body has its own laws and limits and ways of working, like a car, a computer, a plant. Are we aware of ours? Do we respect this vehicle that carries the mind and the soul? It is an instrument, a guitar, how well are you playing it? It is a machine, how well are you running it? And where there is something you would change, height aside, much can be changed with the right effort and discipline and time, so decide honestly what you wish to change; and where something truly cannot be changed, decide instead to accept it, and to carry it into the world with confidence.

Notice, too, how the body shifts with the place you live, the season, the food you eat, the colours you wear, the chemicals you use. And notice the six senses, the doors to the universe, which we almost never think to care for or to sharpen, though it is through their health that we perceive the whole world. As for exercise, there are countless forms, yoga, sport, dance, lifting, swimming, and the real question is what you want the body to be: strong, fast, flexible, enduring? And for what life? A body at a desk all day and a farmer's body are not fed and trained the same. Do you even have a vision of what you want to be? When you are clear about your work and your future, the right food and exercise and rhythm become far easier to choose.

So today, in your zone, after the breath, spend thirty minutes simply thinking about your body: how you will clean it, nourish it, detox it, strengthen it, make it flexible and en-

during, raise its immunity and its tolerance for discomfort. Write it in your journal, in detail. Look honestly at how you have treated it so far. Have you been caring for it consciously, or has it just been drifting, fed whatever was near, slept wherever, bathed only for the look of it?

For now, do no exercises yet; only, if you wish, explore a little, to see how each part is working, whether you can use both sides, how you jump, run, climb, lift, stretch, so that you know where you are starting from. Make the decision to care for it, to understand it, to feed it well, and it will serve you back; there is no doubt of that. And remember, the body is also a memory, carrying the record of generations, and passing it on to the next. Think of it as you eat, as you walk, as you rest: what will this action do to my body? From the next task we will begin at the roots, with cleansing and detoxing; for now, only reflect.

YOUR PRACTICE

After your time on the breath, spend around thirty minutes thinking about your body, and write it down in detail:

- how you have treated it until now, honestly;
- what you want it to become, and for what kind of life;
- how you will clean, feed, strengthen, and care for it.

Through the day, try using your non-dominant hand for small tasks, and notice which parts of the body are strong, stiff, or neglected.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Five: Simple Exercises

FROM THE PAST

The goal is to feel the body, not to count the time. Move slow, like a feather falling from a tree.

There are thousands of foods and lifestyles and exercises, and I cannot teach them all, nor should I. But whoever you are and wherever you are, we are all human, and there is a simple, rooted way that anyone can follow. Here I will show you a few basic movements for life; later you can shape them to yourself as you come to understand your body better.

Think of how you feel on waking, still heavy and slow. Through the night the body makes the chemicals of sleep and healing; simple movement in the morning helps flush them out, lubricate the joints, wake the muscles, and ready you for the day. It takes about thirty minutes, and it leaves you fresh. A few good habits support it: rising before the sun; drinking fresh water, kept in a copper vessel in winter, a clay pot in summer; a little self-massage; joint movement and stretching;

the toilet; a bath. For now we will focus on the movement itself, which everyone should do, whatever their work or body or diet.

Keep the stomach empty; you will not have eaten this early, but wait around thirty minutes after your morning water before you begin. You can do this before your time on the breath or after; try both, and keep what feels best. Two rules hold for every movement. First, always go in order, head to toe or toe to head, never skipping about, so the attention can stay on the muscle and the feeling rather than on counting. Second, always breathe through the nose, even when you feel short of breath; the mouth and stomach are for food, the nose and lungs for breath. When you fold and compress the body, breathe out; when you open and stretch it, breathe in, exactly as the lungs would wish.

Begin with the joints. Start at the toes: notice how each one moves, whether both feet move alike, and gently push a little past the easy range. Move as though a slow, tender scene were playing at half speed. The aim is never to finish or to beat the clock; it is to feel the body, its range, its health, its stiffness, its links to the other parts. Go slowly, two or three times only, holding each stretch until you feel the first hint of strain, never jerking, never forcing. Then move upward, ankles, knees, hips, and so on, joint by joint, missing none, up through the neck and even the eyes. Where a joint is stiff, mark it, and decide to heal it over time.

Then stretch the whole body, again in order, part by part, slow and smooth, feeling for the places that have frozen. And then a little strength work. You need no trainer for this: think

of the movements your ordinary day and home already ask of you, and train those muscles, both sides in proportion, pushing yourself a little. Simple things, push-ups, squats, whatever your body can attempt. Explore it. Play with it. There is no right and wrong here.

A teacher will not stay with you for life; but a habit you discover yourself, in your own body, you will keep for years, and refine, and pass on. My aim is only to plant the seed and help you take the first stroke.

As the days pass, watch the small changes: the movement freeing, the strength coming, the proportions evening out. Feel when the body is loose and when it is tight, when it is heavy, when it is light, when it runs hot or cool, and try to connect that with what you ate and did and felt the day before. It is all joined together. Find your own patterns; we are each unique, living in our own reality. So far we have really learned only two things, to sit and watch the breath, and to observe and move the body, simple, but hard for many, because we have forgotten how to listen to ourselves at all.

YOUR PRACTICE

On an empty stomach, in your zone, move gently through the body in order:

- joint by joint, from the toes upward, two or three slow rounds each;
- then a full slow stretch, head to toe, feeling for the stiff places;
- then simple strength work drawn from your everyday movements, both sides evenly.

Breathe through the nose throughout: out as you fold, in as you open. Feel the body rather than counting, and note the changes day by day in your journal.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Six: The Tongue & Food

FROM THE PAST

You become what you eat, and you can feel it, in every moment, if only you learn to pay attention.

From here we begin to care for the senses one by one, the doors to the world: the eyes to see, the tongue to taste, the ears for sound, the nose for smell, the skin for touch, and one more, intuition, which is really all of them working together with memory and instinct to sense what is coming. There is an old line: if you cannot govern your own senses, what outside you will you ever govern? So we will learn from them, clean them, protect them, and train them, and be the master of the body rather than its servant. We begin with the tongue, with taste and food, one of the most important of all.

REFLECT

Have you ever thought whether taste truly matters for a human? In our tradition there are six tastes, sweet, sour, salty, bitter, pungent, astringent, and each touches a different part of the body and mind; here we were taught to eat according to our body type, our work, the season, and what we wish to become.

Have you ever thought that those who grow the world's food are treated as its poorest and lowest? That despite land everywhere, fruit trees are not planted everywhere to make food abundant, and wondered who decided that, and when, and who funded it? Have you thought that food could have been our medicine and our fuel? Or what really happens to the mind and the body in hunger?

There are countless diets now, countless cuisines and claims. We cannot know or eat everything, and it is genuinely confusing: one scientist says eat this, another says the opposite, and narratives that called a food good are reversed a decade later. We have seen food turned into a weapon, seeds owned and modified to control populations, for there is an old saying that whoever controls hunger controls the mind, and around it sits a vast business of pesticide and seed and machinery and politics.

So, as with everything here, we reflect first, and then we simplify to the root. What is real food? What would nature give us to eat if there were no industry, no machinery, no intervention at all? We will find those foods, and eat them, and study their effect on us, personally.

For this journey, set aside the diet plans of the world, the dieticians and doctors and influencers, ancient or modern. Perhaps their way worked for them; assume it will not simply transfer to your body, because there is no single guide that fits everyone. Instead, make a conscious choice: filter out what is harmful and toxic, and put in what heals. Eat what nature gives directly, grains and cereals, lentils and beans, nuts, fruits, vegetables, seeds, herbs and flowers, and, if it suits your body and your work, eggs, meat, and dairy. Anything within these, but from your local place and by your own hand, nothing processed, packaged, powdered, bottled, or canned by hands you do not know. As for meat, eat by your body and your work and your vision: more plant food to sharpen the mind and the spirit, more meat if your life is heavily physical. Do not eat by social occasion or trend; know who you want to become, and let each choice carry you toward it.

Then filter the factory out, strictly: packaged salt, sugar, oil, water, noodles, bread, all of it, full of preservatives we cannot name. Even organic dried mango in a packet, set it aside, and eat the fresh fruit instead. There are a hundred natural options, pink or sea salt, cold-pressed oil, herbal teas, whole fruits and grains and seeds, all far better than the factory's chemicals, which dull our thinking and our senses so slowly that, like the frog in warming water, we never feel the danger until it is too late.

In the city these things cost more, yes. But ask what you are working for. If not for a good life, clean food, time with family, a healthy body, then what? If you have never thought this through, you are lost, struggling all your life for money you

never spend on the things that make life worth living. So invest, without greed, in food and health and family; the return is a clearer body and mind. And if such food simply cannot be found where you are, then honestly, why are you living there? You have a choice.

FOOD CARRIES A MESSAGE

Here is something I have come to believe, and I want you to sit with it: everything is connected. Season, climate, land, and food all move together. Plants, as I see them, are intelligent; as the seasons and the climate shift, they read the change through air and water and the life in the soil, and they build into each food, I believe, exactly what the living things around them will need to adapt, to meet the coming cold, the coming illness. When we eat local, seasonal food, that information enters us and readies us for the change that is actually coming here, where we live. This is also why no single food, however natural, is right all year, and why food grown far away cannot serve you as fully; food flown from another continent still feeds you, but it was preparing bodies for that place, not yours.

There is a term for this worth knowing: food mile, the distance your food travels to reach your plate, and all the energy and transport and labour spent to bring it there. Put some effort into shortening it. Eat local, support the local grower and the local economy, and you also stay closer to the nature and the season you are actually living in. Too often it is the big franchises and multinationals that hollow out local farms, local business, and the faith and unity of a place, so buying local is not only healthier for you, it keeps a community alive.

Every body, every climate, every soil and season is different; even one family eating the same food from the same land is affected differently, person to person. Small differences in our chemistry and our digestive fire make a large difference in the end. Think of homesickness: even with your whole family beside you, you would still feel it, because, the way I understand it, the body itself misses the air and the water and the warmth and the very microbes of home. That is how deep I believe the bond between a body and its place runs. In time you adapt, but it is worth knowing.

One good practice is to eat single foods sometimes, unmixed, without covering them in salt and oil and spice, so that the tongue meets the true taste and the body learns exactly what it is receiving and how to digest it. Keep a record, too, of what you eat; we have lost the art of feeling our food, of using it as medicine and as fuel, of noticing what it does to us.

And how do you learn what a food does? By observing. The next morning, sitting in your zone, recall what you ate the day before, and connect it to everything, to your thoughts, your sleep, your focus on the breath, the ease or stiffness of the body in its movements. Do you feel heavy or light, hot or cool, calm or agitated? That is the power of food; it can make you dense or clear, restless or at peace. Until you can feel these subtle effects in your own body, consider that you have not yet passed this task. It may take months. Through the day, on the bus, at rest, pause, breathe, and feel what the body is telling you. This one habit, to stop and reflect, saves a great deal of anger and burnout and quiet despair, and brings a clarity that ripples out into everything around you.

YOUR PRACTICE

For this journey, eat only what nature gives, from your local place, by your own hand:

- whole grains, lentils, nuts, fruits, vegetables, seeds, herbs; and meat, eggs, or dairy if they suit your body and work;
- nothing processed, packaged, bottled, canned, or made in factories you do not know.

Sometimes eat a food alone, unspiced, to meet its true taste. Each morning, recall what you ate and connect it to how your body and mind feel. Keep a food record in your journal.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Seven: The Skin & Its Care

FROM THE PAST

Understand who you really are, from the inside out. Do not build yourself from chemicals and coverings; build from the core.

REFLECT

Have you ever liked someone by their looks, yet felt hollow beside them? Wanted to go somewhere, then disliked it once you arrived? Thought you wanted a certain job, or house, or food, and found yourself drifting from it? Have you questioned why we grow hair and are then made to feel we must remove it, hide it, be ashamed of it, and asked who taught us that, and when? Or why people paint themselves with cosmetics to be beautiful, and yet are drawn to those who wear none?

And you must have noticed that some people smell bad to you and others good, and that the very same person smells good to someone else. We each have our own scent and our own receptors; this is nature's way. So consider how the chemicals and perfumes and cosmetics we pile on are covering our true selves, and letting us be steered by manufactured smells and mass advertising.

Think about the skin. It is our largest sense organ; it covers the whole body, and, though we forget it, it breathes. It absorbs what is around it, temperature, moisture, air, sunlight, moonlight, wind, and chemicals; it helps regulate sweat and heat and waste. It is very much alive. Yet in this era we smother it in perfumes and cosmetics, block its pores, and chase a fairness sold to us by films and the cosmetics industry, never asking why our skin is the colour it is, that its pigment answers to the sun and the climate we live in.

These chemicals also dull the sense of touch itself, so that we feel less of the temperature and pressure and freshness and moisture the skin was made to read. So the practice is simple: cut the chemicals, and return to the natural form. For this

task, filter out every chemical and factory product you put on the body, strictly and completely, no matter what the label claims, natural, bio, fair-trade; if it was made in a factory and comes in plastic, set it aside. Soap, shampoo, conditioner, perfume, cosmetics, face wash, foundation, sunscreen, lipstick, toothpaste, hair oil. Let the skin breathe and absorb what is truly around it, and let your own scent be itself, so you can begin to feel what you really are.

THE WITHDRAWAL

When you stop, there will be a kind of withdrawal, because that is how these products, and our habits, work; we grow dependent so quickly, on substances as on people and ideas. The skin may dry or crack, the hair may feel rough. Let it heal. Let it learn to stop spending, and become natural again. You will feel uncomfortable, and so will some people around you; you may feel small, you may notice your own smell for the first time. Let them be surprised. They do not know your journey, and you owe them no proof, because you are doing this for yourself, to meet your natural self and to learn to accept it. People are unsettled by sudden change, but it passes within a week; they adapt and stop noticing. One quiet gift of this is that, as your natural scent returns, you begin to filter your life the way all of nature does, by smell, sensing which people and foods and places are truly for you and which are not.

ON CLEANLINESS AND LIVING BACTERIA

Here is a belief of mine that the modern world will fight, and I will say it plainly, because I have lived it. We have made a god of being clean, and it is making us weak. I come from the hills, where there were no fancy medicines and no sterile rooms, and I watched people live strong well past a hundred years, close to the soil, the animals, the rain, the mud. The body was never made to be sealed inside a bubble. Bacteria are not the enemy; the more the body meets them, the more it learns to handle them and the stronger it grows, and a child kept too clean grows into an adult with a weaker, more frightened body. Cutting yourself off from the life of the earth does not protect you. It leaves you defenceless.

Let me draw the line clearly, so no one mistakes me. I am not telling you to drink filthy water, or to roll in waste. Clean water and basic sanitation are real gifts, and they have saved more lives than we can count, and I would never take them from anyone. What I stand against is the other thing: the obsession, the antibacterial everything, the fear of a speck of dirt, the pill reached for at every small discomfort. That obsession is what dulls the body's own power to heal and to fight. So get honestly dirty sometimes. Play in the mud and the rain. Let a small cut close on its own. Trust your body a little more, and the chemist's shelf a little less.

After sweating or bathing, wipe down with a clean cotton towel, change your clothes daily, bathe daily; that is enough to stay clean and keep the balance right. For washing the body you can try natural things, aloe, neem, soap nut, shikakai, and learn which suits you in which season, for the same thing that

soothes in summer may harm in winter. This is the interesting part: to stay awake to the season and the day and the state of your own body, and to change with them. That is what it is to be human.

A few more things. Wear colourful clothes. Learn to feel a little pain rather than reaching at once for medicine over small cuts; let the body learn to heal itself. When you bathe, if living without soap in a polluted city is hard, there is a trick: exercise first and sweat, which loosens the dead skin and oil, then bathe, ideally in cold water, and you will be clean enough while keeping the helpful bacteria. Massage the body before the morning bath to ease the withdrawal from chemicals. For washing clothes some chemical may be unavoidable; use the most eco-friendly option you can, and rinse until it is completely gone, so that it never sits against your skin for long. Spend time in the morning and evening sun, in the moon, in the wind; let the skin feel and heal and return to its own form, and learn to accept that form, without the coverings. There are natural fragrances too, if you truly want them, but keep them for special use and do not grow dependent.

Colonisation of the body has not ended; it only moved from the land to the screen and the shelf. These smells and coatings are part of the detachment you feel, from people, food, place, work, and self. Wake up before it is too late.

YOUR PRACTICE

Gather every chemical and factory product from the bathroom, kitchen, and room, and pack them away for the length of the journey. In their place:

- let the skin breathe; use only natural things to wash, and learn what suits your body and the season;
- bathe daily and change clothes daily; wipe with a clean cotton towel;
- spend time each day with sun, moon, and wind on the skin, and let small wounds heal on their own.

Watch the withdrawal pass, and write in your journal what you begin to feel once the coverings are gone.

PART ONE • THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Eight: Protect the Ears

FROM THE PAST

Sound alters the mind faster than any other sense. Be careful, then, what you let yourself hear.

REFLECT

What is the range of your hearing? Could you tell, with your eyes closed, where a sound is coming from, and how far? Do you have sounds and voices you love and others you cannot bear, and is that tied to memory? Why does one person's speech soothe you and another's grate?

Do you think every sound affects you, and that some sound could steer you without your knowing? Do the television, the radio, the endless advertisements shape your thoughts? Should you really believe and react to everything you hear, and if not, how do you filter it? And what, do you think, is the sound of the earth and the universe? Sit with these, and look for your own answers.

In this task we protect the ears. Here is the habit we must watch: we hear something and react at once, without stopping to understand it or to check it, a story, a piece of news, a history, an idea from a book, a song. But these are not your truth; they are someone else's experience, someone else's perspective, reaching you through a single sense. Every myth and story and history is another person's telling. You did not live it with your whole body and mind; you received it through the ear alone, and to assume at once that it is true or false, and to act, is a dangerous impulse in this age, one that can quietly govern how you think and choose.

Keep the mind open, yes, take the information in, but separate taking it in from acting on it, because every action changes the course of a life. Be careful which words you let move you, and which you simply file away. So far as you can, make your choices and act where you are physically and mentally present, in your own environment, among the things actually happening around you, rather than reacting to news from the far side of the world. Let the people there deal with what is theirs; be present and useful where you are.

THE MUSIC WE DROWN IN

Think of how many people now cannot walk down a street, eat, work, or rest without music in their ears. That is a heavy dependency, and a real problem, for if you cannot bear to hear your own thoughts, or nature, or what is happening around you, you are quietly running from reality. Music is powerful; it moves the emotions and the body faster than sight or almost any other sense, through its rhythm, its mood, and above all

what it is tied to in your memory. It is said that in old kingdoms, rulers sent musicians as spies, to learn how an enemy thought and lived through the music they kept. And in the old Sanskrit tradition, sound and mantra were used to alter states and, the stories say, reality itself; you can see a little of it in the way a song can calm a troubled mind, or lift a heavy one.

I will tell you my own belief here, and you can take it or leave it. I feel that some music sits closer to the calm of nature than other music, and when I can, I choose to tune a little lower, nearer to what some call 432, because it feels more settled in my body. There is even old history in it: the composer Verdi once argued for a lower pitch, for the ease of the singers. I cannot prove any of this to you with numbers, and I will not pretend to; the difference in pitch is small. But that is the whole point, that music works on you deeply and quickly, so choose it with care.

So be careful what you call your favourite music, and where you take it from. Much of it is free, and it is worth asking why it is so freely poured into places like ours. Notice that those who lead and create and break out of the rat race tend to be those who consume the least of this, who spend less of their lives inside the screen and the feed. Physical colonisation has stopped, but a mental and spiritual one continues through the internet and the phone, and we have to protect ourselves, our people, and our culture from it.

What to do instead: listen live, in your community, with your friends and family. Learn to play one instrument, even badly; keep it in your life. Gather people and play together, teach someone; this heals us, and heals the community. Above

all, be present to natural sound, wind, water, insects, birds, the voices of the people actually around you; it grounds you in what is real and near, and helps you see and solve the problems that are actually yours. To train the ear, learn a little music, or practise, eyes closed, locating where each sound comes from, as a game in idle moments; and learn, too, to use your own voice well, even to sing.

YOUR PRACTICE

For this journey, take the constant feed of recorded music and noise out of your ears, and in its place:

- listen to natural sound, and to the real voices around you;
- when you want music, seek it live, in your community, or make it yourself;
- practise, eyes closed, tracing where a sound comes from.

Before reacting to anything you only heard, secondhand news, a story, a claim, pause and ask whether you are truly present to it, or receiving it through one sense alone.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Nine: The Eye & Vision

FROM THE PAST

*A wise person questions even what he sees, and
thinks many times before he reacts.*

REFLECT

If you saw a dog chasing a cat, would you also see the reasons behind it? What is your favourite colour, and where did that favouring come from? By now perhaps you sense that there is no such thing as a favourite; it is a small trick that separates you from reality and sets you playing at like and hate. Every colour, every sound, every person affects you, one way or another; the real work is to learn how each affects you, not to hide inside an illusion of favourites you never examined.

There is first-hand seeing, what happens around you, at home, in the family, the street, the community, where your whole body is present and alive; and there is second-hand seeing, the internet, television, newspaper, poster, the events of distant places. We cannot control what we see first-

hand; it simply happens, and we weigh it and decide how to hold it. But second-hand images are someone's creation. You were not there in body; you meet them only through the eye and the ear, unable to touch or smell or test them. They are stories, and they can be shaped, edited, slanted by whoever tells them, so they cannot be trusted fully. This very book is second-hand for you, so do not simply believe me; check for yourself, and use your common sense.

Not long ago the world was smaller. We saw mainly what happened around us, and built our sense of reality from that; the television was entertainment. We discussed life face to face, expressed our anger and love and support with our whole bodies present in real events. Then the phone arrived, a remarkable tool, and we began to act and react through a screen without grasping its limits, how poorly it carries the real weight of a human feeling. The whole world came to our fingertip, which is a wonder, all those languages and cultures in real time, but with it we began to forget the real world at hand, our own family and culture and problems, and to imagine we belonged to a global culture without ever asking who was promoting it, and why.

Most of the time we do not even know what we are looking for; we are just scrolling, in a queue, on a break, in the toilet, and what began as fun becomes a trap. We are shown what an algorithm wants us to see, shaped by where we live and by whoever wants to sell us something or spread a message, and it has become a vast machine of manipulation and a marketplace for the powerful. We rarely remember what we watched, rarely learn from it, rarely check whether it was even true. So

we must take the control back into our own hands, and choose what we want to know and see, for our own growth, our own plans, our own future. Because, as with food and sound, we become what we see; and the eye is one of the senses we trust most quickly, taking whatever comes as reality, when on the phone that is very often the opposite of the truth.

So how? Just as we have grown a little conscious of the breath, the body, food, and sound, we now grow conscious of what we take in through the eye. Much of it can be settled with a little effort. On the phone, use the settings: turn off the auto-playing feeds, the history, the data harvesting, the advertisements you can; browse privately; use the tools that put you back in control. Read the terms; ask questions of it rather than merely consuming what it pushes, for in our culture there is wisdom in the idea that the more you ask, the more you know. Be someone who asks. When you stop the endless auto-feed, you will notice how often you reach for the phone with no real purpose, only habit, to kill a little time; and finding nothing served up to you, you will drift back into the present, into what is actually around you, which is where real life and real problems and real people are. Living too much in a virtual world is not healthy for the eyes or the mind; it shapes our behaviour and our ability to meet real humans and solve real problems. It is telling that many of the people who build these technologies keep their own children away from the screen until they are grown.

A FEW PRACTICES FOR THE EYE

Wash the eyes with cold water before and after sleep. Learn how different colours act on the mind and the memory, and notice what the colour of your room and your clothes is doing to you. Take up drawing or painting as a hobby. Rest your eyes on natural things, the horizon, sunrise and sunset, moon and stars, river and forest and sky; travel, and see the world for yourself. React to the events and problems and possibilities of your own life and community, and leave the distant quarrels of the internet to those who live inside them. Sleep in a fully dark room, or by natural moonlight, and on nature's time as the season turns.

Learn, too, to see with the inner eye. If a dog chases a cat, you can call it cruelty, or nature, or play, or a quarrel over food; it is you who chooses which to believe, and that choice becomes your reality, so learn to hold several readings of a scene before you leap to one and act. And learn to see in dreams: if each morning you recall your dreams and write them, and recall them again through the day and before sleep, you will slowly remember them longer and more vividly, and in time even become aware and awake within them. Then you live two lives, one of waking reality and one of dream, an art people once cultivated for many purposes.

YOUR PRACTICE

Take back control of what enters through the eye:

- turn off auto-feeds and reach for the phone only with a real purpose;
- rest the eyes daily on natural things, and wash them with cold water at night;
- sleep in darkness or moonlight; take up drawing; begin recording your dreams.

When you see something, practise holding more than one explanation before you judge or react.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Ten: The Nose & Smell

FROM THE PAST

The nose and lungs are for breathing; the mouth and stomach are for food. Remember this.

Of all the senses, smell is the oldest and the most secret. It runs straight to memory and to feeling, faster than thought; a single scent can drop you into a moment from twenty years ago, or turn your mood in an instant, and you rarely notice it happening. Through all of nature, living things use smell to find the right food, the right mate, the right place to be. It is a quiet compass. And it is exactly this compass, I believe, that the modern world has learned to jam, flooding us with manufactured scents, in our soaps, our rooms, our food, on our own bodies, to sell us things and to cover what is real. So in this task we clear the nose, and give it back to nature.

REFLECT

What smells take you straight back to childhood, to a person, to a place? Which ones calm you, and which put you on edge, and can you feel your mood shift the moment they reach you?

Of all the scents around you in a day, how many are real, and how many are manufactured, on your skin, your clothes, your room, your food? Write down what you notice.

Now the care itself. Always breathe through the nose, whatever you are doing. Keep it clean and stop digging at it; clean it while bathing, breathing through it even then, and when you have finished simply blow it clear, or use a finger and pure water, never soap or any chemical.

Keep resting the attention on the breath, as we learned, wherever you can, on the road, on the bus, in the small waits of the day. And turn the sense of smell back toward nature: take time to smell the land, the water, the air, the flowers, the food; close your eyes and meet different scents on purpose. Learn which smell stirs which part of your memory and mood, and how scents can move and even steer you, so that you can begin to notice it and stay free of it. Prefer the scents of nature to the chemicals we have discussed, for the same reasons we cut them from the skin: they dull the sense and manufacture false feeling.

If the place you live in does not smell clean and natural, and cannot, then ask honestly what you are doing there. Do not lie to yourself with your reasons and obligations. There are countless places on this earth; you have a choice.

And a small, practical trust: since a chemical scent covers the true one, be slow to fully trust anyone who is always masked in it, until you have either a plain agreement in writing or enough time with them, unperfumed, to sense who they really are.

YOUR PRACTICE

Breathe only through the nose, and keep it clean with water alone. Each day, spend a little time smelling nature with your eyes closed, and notice which scents move your mood and memory, and how. Prefer natural scent to chemical, and write what you notice.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Eleven: Fasting & Intuition

FROM THE PAST

*One comes to know oneself in times of hunger.
Hunger has always pushed us past our limits,
and out of comfort, to think and dare and sur-
vive.*

REFLECT

Have you truly felt hunger? This modern world rarely has, with food in countless forms always at hand; many people now feel they will collapse without eating for even a few hours. But recall: have you, or anyone in your community, ever actually died of hunger for lack of trying? Humans always find food to survive, even those in the jungle, even those on the road. So do not fear it.

And think back: when did your most creative and daring ideas and choices come? Very often at night, or on some hike, in some uncalculated moment, and very often when your stomach had been empty for six hours or more. Look for that pattern in your own past. It may have been happening unconsciously; now we will do it on purpose.

Our body, and our mind and spirit too, need to learn to be hungry, in order to heal and grow. There are many forms of fasting now, and many traditions and reasons behind them, physical, mental, spiritual; explore them for yourself, with an open mind.

Here is the practice: begin to fast once a week, on water, or else once in the fortnight by the moon. In our calendar the eleventh day from both the new and the full moon, *ekadashi*, is a strong day for such a fast. Make no excuses for it; simply do it. One honest word first, though: this is a practice for a healthy body, so if yours carries a real condition, diabetes, pregnancy, great age or great youth, recovery from illness, or a past struggle with the way you eat, then shape it to yourself or set it aside, and trust your own judgement. Do not harm yourself to prove a point. Otherwise, take it as a day to rest the di-

gestive system, to spend less energy, to train the body toward calm survival, and to train the mind and spirit in self-control, in sacrifice, in keeping a commitment, and in trusting the process. If you can, rest from heavy work as well; sit, relax, reflect, heal. An easy day.

Two cautions. The fast really begins the day before and ends the day after, so do not gorge on a heavy meal or meat the night before, thinking you must stock up, nor break greedily the day after; that craving does more harm than the fast does good. If you open a vessel that is under pressure all at once, it bursts; release it slowly. Eat light the day before and the day after. And when you break the fast, begin with water or something light and liquid, fruit, soaked nuts, a soup of vegetables or lentils, in a small portion, and only after an hour eat a little more, still light. Whole fruit is better than juice: eat the whole food, local and sweet.

YOUR PRACTICE

Fast on water once a week, or by the moon at ekadashi. Around it:

- eat light the day before and the day after; do not gorge or break greedily;
- break the fast with water, then fruit or a light soup, and only later eat a little more;
- use the day to rest, reflect, and heal, and note in your journal what hunger shows you.

PART ONE • THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Twelve: Recall Before Sleep

FROM THE PAST

The one who refuses to look back will never truly see ahead. Past, present, and future are not separate; they are one thing.

If we live only in the present, we lose the thread; if we live only for the future, we miss our life; if we dwell only in the past, we lose what is ahead. So each day we learn to move through all three: in the morning, be present in yourself and your surroundings; in the day, work with others toward the future; in the evening, relax; and before sleep, recall the day, weigh the present, and re-plan what is to come.

Let us gather what we have built. We made a personal space, a place to reflect and grow. We began to watch the breath, and to understand and clear the mind. We turned attention to the body, with movement and care. We came to understand food and to eat with awareness. We filtered the chemicals from the skin. We are filtering what we let ourselves

hear, and see, and smell. We are fasting once a week or by the moon. This task is the last of the daily round: at night, when everything is finished and you go to bed, recall the whole day.

First finish your washing and your journal and go to bed clean, in a dark room or by natural moonlight; you will spend six or eight hours there almost lifeless, so let the body rest and heal rather than fight what a dirty bed breeds. No music, no incense, no room freshener, only the sound of nature; do not seal the room completely, let it breathe. Lie flat and relaxed, and let yourself sink. Close the eyes, take a few long breaths, loosen the hands and legs, settle the pillow.

Now begin to recall the day. Move through it quickly first, whatever comes easily to mind. A second time, go through it in order, arranging the memories as they truly happened. A third time, dig a little deeper. The more detail you can recover, the stronger and healthier the mind and the memory become. What did you do in the morning, and how did you feel, and what was the weather, and the day of the moon; what did you do at midday, and in the evening; what did you eat, whom did you meet, what did you see and smell and think? Everything.

There is one danger here: while recalling, you may start to like or hate some moment and drift into imagining it otherwise, into what you wish had happened. Do not. Stay with the facts, with what truly occurred. This is how we learn to see reality and accept it as it is.

Keep to your own first-hand life, not what someone told you or what you saw on a screen; this is your world, your reality. When the recalling is done, turn to the body, as you did in the morning, from toe to head or head to toe, and let each part relax and heal and grow light, as a feather falling into sleep. Be grateful to it. Imagine it growing healthier. Do this and you will sleep deeply and wake fresh, clear, and steady.

And in the morning the round begins again, and so a full circle forms: preparing in the morning, living the day consciously, and ending at night in reflection and healing. This is the circle of the journey, of becoming better at being human, and within it you slowly become the master of your own life, your decisions and visions and purpose beginning, at last, to make sense.

YOUR PRACTICE

Each night, clean and in a dark, quiet room, lie down and recall the whole day, three times over, from quick to detailed, keeping strictly to the facts. Then relax the body part by part, be grateful to it, and let yourself fall asleep. Do this to close each day of the journey.

PART ONE · THE INNER JOURNEY

Task Thirteen: The Skills of a Human

FROM THE PAST

Jack of all trades, master of none, is better than a master of one. The complete human is hard to buy and hard to control.

This is the last of the daily tasks, and one of the most important. Begin with a truth about ourselves. Whatever you feel, joy or sorrow, anger or peace, is made by the same chemicals and hormones inside the same body. The one who feels good drinking and harming himself and the one who feels good reading and improving himself are running on the same inner chemistry; so are the lazy and the active, the one who eats poorly and the one who eats well. What differs is only what we were taught, where we live, the circle we keep, all the external things we attach our happiness to. But the consequences differ enormously: harm yourself in the name of

fun and you grow weaker and duller, and the child you one day make will be less healthy than you; keep yourself well and learning, and your body makes healthier humans.

REFLECT

So the choice is yours: to be happy by destroying yourself, or by improving yourself? What does it mean, to you, to be human, to live and die caring for nothing beyond yourself, or to live responsibly, for the generations and the nature that come after? Both kinds of people feel joy and pain; the chemistry is the same. It is only what you attach it to, and what it leaves behind, that differs.

I know people who see a life on the screen and long for it, the car, the house, the money, the parties, yet have no interest in learning anything and no plan at all. They want only the finished product, never the work, and most of them do not know who they are or what they want, so they simply follow whatever the feed is following. That is not a life. A human must learn to understand the self, to find a purpose, to dream widely, to plan, and to work. Few teach this now, and fewer still have the patience to sit through an hour of it, because the culture of the endless short clip has worn away our very ability to listen long enough to learn. So ask yourself plainly: do you want to be a learner, a doer, a maker, or a dreamer who only consumes and suffers?

No one is perfect, and that is nature; no two mango trees are alike, no two days, no two of any creature. Our flaws and differences, our colours and shapes and heights, are what make us singular, and we must learn to cherish that rather

than chase a false perfection. The idea that we must each master one narrow thing is, to me, a way of fitting a person into a corporate box, to labour in one department and spend all he earns depending on every other, a closed loop of work and money and quiet servitude. We are meant instead to be many-sided.

A METHOD FOR ANYTHING

There is one habit of mind worth carrying into everything:

- imagine, brainstorm, and map the idea or task;
- research it, and compare many sources;
- redesign it to fit your own need;
- build, make, or create it;
- put it to use;
- and share it with everyone.

This works everywhere, in cooking, exercise, art, music, building, family, business, anything. Every human should learn it. And beyond it, we should learn to use the whole of the mind and body and spirit. Imagine the body is a musical instrument: will you leave it in the corner, or learn to play it as well as you can? None of this happens overnight; it is the work of a life. But simply holding the aim will carry you toward these things naturally, if now and then you push yourself and choose them over easier ways to pass the time.

WHAT A HUMAN MIGHT BE CURIOUS ABOUT

Be curious about the cosmos, the stars and their cycles and their effect on the earth and on the body; about the earth itself, our home, its elements and climates and rhythms and our bond with it; about the animals and plants and microbes we share it with, and our duty to survive alongside them; about food, its formation, and the bridge it makes between nature and us, and about how to grow and gather and store and share it. Be curious about the self, mind, body, and spirit, and how to train them; and, once you know yourself, about other humans, which grows far easier then. Be curious about the language of nature, which is mathematics and science, the means to measure and record and design; and about machines, computers, and the new tools, and how to use them for the good of humans and nature rather than against them.

And last, art. Most people think art means music, dance, painting, drama, film, because those are what the world holds up. But consider that you yourself, body and mind and spirit, are art. Billions of years of dust and movement and climate and evolution, your family's whole history, every place your ancestors lived, every illness and ray of sun and turn of society, all of it made you, and after birth your family and culture and food and routine went on making you, so that no one else is quite as you are. The way you walk, speak, think, sit, choose your clothes, write, sing, all of it is unique; all of it is art. Be proud of it. No one else need like your art; each has their own taste. But as an artist you must be able to meet other art too, to receive it, question it, and answer it, without copying it and without shrinking before it. This age of celebrity has hollowed

out people's confidence, teaching them to worship a few who set the trends and the standards, and to forget that they too are art. So trust what made you, work to grow and refine your own art, and make your own style, your own walk, your own way. Be bold. Forget the notion of one standard dress, one standard sound, one standard life.

Hunatian: a human of the future.

These are some of the things worth staying curious about, and returning to, across a life: the self and its purpose and duty; family and community and our bond with them; space, and nature, and our bond with each; true history, religion, and myth; technology and its daily use; travel, exploration, and service; and our purpose as humans on this earth. And these are some of the skills and disciplines worth reaching for over a lifetime, not all at once, but as a direction to grow in: to use both sides of the body, and to train many kinds of intelligence, of body and mind and feeling and language and art; yoga, and many forms of exercise and sport; meditation; some knowledge of astrology and vastu; farming; carpentry; work with metals, and with clay; mechanics; the language of computers and the new tools; swimming; music; riding; something of electricity; and the reading and writing of stories, the art of imagination and of expression.

YOUR PRACTICE

Choose to be a maker rather than only a consumer. In your journal, begin two lists and return to them across the journey and beyond:

- the fields you want to stay curious about, self, nature, space, food, history, technology, service;
- the skills and disciplines you want to reach for over your life.

Practise the method, imagine, research, redesign, build, use, share, on one real thing this week, however small.

PART ONE · CLOSING

The End of Part One

This is the whole of the beginner's journey inward. It is simple, and it is hard, and it depends entirely on you. If you can hold to it for three months without breaking, you will be blessed with its fruit, and I will not need to explain that fruit to you; you will see who you have become, and you will be grateful to yourself.

Not many complete it on the first attempt. Keep trying. You will not regret it. And if you do complete it, keep it to yourself; it was never about the challenge or a final test, but about your life. No one needs to know. Or, if you believe it could help someone, share it once you are done. I want nothing from you but this: one more awakened human on this earth, capable, disciplined, curious, a thinker and a doer. That, in the end, makes the earth a little better. One fewer sheep in the race makes even the race more interesting.

In this journey you may feel more lost than found, for a while, and that is its beauty. Make it your life, not a one-year challenge. You will lose people, places, habits, and

even things you thought were your purpose, and you will find, each time, that you were only filtering away what never truly mattered.

You may cry, and suffer, and ache, and you will also find a deep happiness inside all of it. Do not stop. You will lose friends, interests, perhaps your job and career along the way; do not worry, for you will come out of it a confident human, capable enough to build your own life and your own path. In time, you will find yourself. That is the point of all of it.

PART TWO

The Outer Journey

You alone do not make your life. Around you are the utensils, the cloth, the walls, the waste, the people, the schools, and the endless wants of the world. Having worked on the self, we now turn outward, and filter what surrounds it.

PART TWO • THE OUTER JOURNEY

Filter Your Kitchen Utensils

We are looking now at the things we are joined to that touch our health directly, and the vessels we cook and eat from are among the most important, though we hardly think of them. Teflon, aluminium, plastic, these affect us in ways we can well imagine; there is research if you want it, but you hardly need it. Use your common sense, and act.

Knowingly or not, we harm ourselves and our families and the generations after us. In many homes the money for good vessels is genuinely tight; in others it is only that no one has stopped to think, or that a slow poison does not feel like poison, so we tell ourselves we have always done it this way and are still alive, and let it be, and never connect it to why we feel unwell, why the mind will not clear, why nothing seems to be truly living. Healthy food cooked in an unhealthy vessel is like drying yourself with a dirty towel after a clean bath. What is the point?

So begin to filter the kitchen too. Start with plastic, with Teflon coatings, with aluminium, and set aside the high-pressure pots. Move toward clay, ceramic, copper, brass, iron, stone, glass. Replace them one at a time, as you can afford to.

Each material has its own uses and its own cautions, so study a little; do not, for instance, cook or store sour food in copper. Change the cooking vessels first, then the eating ones, then the storage jars. In most cases it is a one-time investment, and it returns health and clarity and nourishment to the whole family. The kitchen is the heart of the home and the place of fire; invest in it, and let health and prosperity spread from there.

YOUR PRACTICE

Over three days: on the first, research the materials and their uses; on the second, go through everything in your kitchen and sort what must go; on the third, begin replacing what you can, starting with your own daily vessels, with clay, iron, brass, copper, stone, or glass.

PART TWO · THE OUTER JOURNEY

Filter Your Clothes

After the home, our clothes are our next shelter. We use them against the climate and for modesty and to express ourselves, but do we ever ask what they are made of, and whether they make us healthier? Mostly we just wear what we have, or what the screen and the paid influencer showed us. There are, rightly, clothes engineered for specific work, for fire, water, sport, safety; these are tools, and we need them. But much of what we wear all day, every day, is made of plastic fibre, nylon, polyester, petroleum, never meant to sit against the skin for long hours over years.

So go through the closet and see what you have, and choose, consciously, to make your daily and first choice what nature gives: cotton, linen, silk, wool, plant fibres. Do the same with bed sheets and furniture fabrics. Let your clothing heal you rather than quietly drain you, and keep plastic and petroleum off your skin and out of the air you breathe indoors. Keep colour in your wardrobe, too, rather than a single shade; every colour has its properties, lighter for sun and summer, darker

for winter, and colour works on the mood and the mind more than we credit, so learn a little and choose by your life and your climate.

And buy locally where you can, to support the local economy, for like food, cloth carries the story of where it came from. If you love a design you saw online, take it to a nearby tailor and have it made; it is often cheaper, and it is yours. Do not chase trends and brands.

YOUR PRACTICE

Sort your clothes and bedding. Make natural fibres, cotton, linen, silk, wool, your everyday first choice, and keep the synthetic, engineered pieces for the specific work they were made for. Add colour by season and need, and buy local or have it made where you can.

PART TWO • THE OUTER JOURNEY

Filter What Surrounds You

Think now about the house and the environment you live in, and the materials you are surrounded by. Consider how we grow: we are born without our consent, guided by our parents as they believe best, placed in the environment and school they choose, then asked by this failing system to take our place in one of its branches as a job, to marry, build a house, follow some religion or party or idol, and die, a good and orderly life in the service of the system. That system is not accidental; it is designed by those with power and business and influence, and it links media, food, medicine, school, politics, technology, even love and family, so that everything leads back to the same place. Everything we are learning to filter was carefully built into it to keep us playing the same game, and to hand another human life down to do it all again.

So let me say it plainly. If the place where you live and work and struggle cannot give you these things, you should think seriously about changing it:

- fresh water, clean air, living land, and exposure to sun and moon;

- a natural, healthy house to live in;
- quiet mornings, good rest, health, and peace;
- local, organic food of real variety;
- three generations of family living together in unity;
- a supportive, progressive, wise community;
- your own or a family livelihood, ethical and rooted;
- access to books, to the internet, to ethical technology and clean energy and transport;
- contact with the wider world, its cultures and travellers;
- and access to art and craft, to music and dance and sport, close to home.

These are the very things a life is for. Why sacrifice all of them merely to chase money? I know such a place can sound like a dream, but then dream of it, and work toward it, look for it, or design and build one yourself. It is a gift to yourself, to those you love, to your parents, and to the children yet to come, for how you live and shape your body is passed down in your genes. Do not, out of a narrow selfishness, make another unhealthy child in an unhealthy place and call it success. And if you feel alone in this, you are not; there are millions of us, scattered and disconnected across the earth, each doing our part. That matters. Think now, and act now.

PART TWO • THE OUTER JOURNEY

Manage Your Waste

First ask where all this waste comes from, and who makes it. In a place like Nepal we do not produce it, so how does it arrive here? Plastic came late to our villages, and it came without any warning or any way to manage it. Before it, we used cloth and cotton and leaf plates for our festivals, we carried things in wood and bamboo and cloth, and we could throw what was left back to nature without harm, because it belonged to nature. So when plastic came, we treated it the same way, as though it too would return quietly to the earth. We ate the biscuits and drank the colas and threw the wrappers wherever we stood, never taught the consequences.

We once kept our water sources holy and clean, guarding them even with stories of snakes and gods so that no one would foul them; now we rinse with shampoo and toss the sachet in without a thought. Every time we shop we bring home ten or twenty more bags, though we have bags at home, because we cannot be bothered to carry our own, and the companies are glad, since their logo on the bag is another small advertisement carried through the street.

Do we truly need all this plastic, or was it simply that the oil companies found a way to make products from petroleum waste and sell them? Is this what our technology is for? Can we really not make packaging that returns to the earth? These are fair questions to hold. For now, the work is to become conscious of it.

YOUR PRACTICE

Keep track of the waste you and your family actually produce, the plastic, the cans, the wrappers. Trace where each thing comes from, cut off what you can, reuse what you can, and separate the rest. Carry your own bag. Treat your water sources as the older people did, as something holy to be kept clean.

PART TWO • THE OUTER JOURNEY

Filter the People Around You

FROM THE PAST

Every other human will leave, in time. At the end, it is you who stays with you. Learn to hear yourself.

Every human can be what they choose, and no two are alike; habits and tastes and ways of living differ, and that is as it should be. In a single life you will meet every kind of person, kind and cruel, honest and cunning, generous and lazy, and you cannot control that, because family and community and circumstance bring them, and we can never be surrounded only by the good. Even if you gathered the wisest and healthiest people and withdrew into an ideal society, the small human things would still arise, the comparisons, the gossip, the misunderstandings, the little groups; we cannot escape these ordinary emotions.

So the best you can do is to see clearly where you stand and who is truly around you. You cannot change another person; even if you could hold them for a while by your presence, someone else will move them again once you are gone. So do not try. Share what you think, but never expect another human to become what you want them to be. Knowing them well is the real work, and with that knowledge you can decide, calmly, how to spend your time, whom to partner with, whom to keep close, and from whom to step quietly away. You owe no one a justification. In silence, observe; in silence, stay or go.

Because in the end every other person leaves, parents, partner, children, friends, community, and it is you who spends every hour of your life with you, you who must work with you until you die. So learn to listen to yourself, above all, though only after you have built yourself strong and knowledgeable enough to trust and guide yourself. Make your own perspective and purpose, and make it the best you can, for the sake of a healthier nature and a better generation to come. And if your family or friends or community will not support that life, do not fight them, do not blame them; simply, in silence, leave, and find the people who care about life and the earth and the future. You can still try to inspire them by your own example, but you must not let those who are destroying life and nature and the future hold you in place.

PART TWO · THE OUTER JOURNEY

Filter Teacher & School

FROM THE PAST

Ask questions, more and more, and above all of yourself. If you have stopped questioning, you are already asleep.

Ask questions, of your parents, your friends, your gurus, your leaders, your doctors and scientists, and especially your teachers. Ask them why they teach these particular chapters, and what they are preparing you for. Ask about the real problems of the real world, and how to solve them. Bring them your own problems and ask them to help: to fix the furniture, the toilet, the wiring, the computer, the household and business accounts; to teach you a routine, and exercise; to teach you real trade and business; to teach you farming and food; to teach you your own body, mind, and spirit, and its bond with nature and the cosmos; to teach you true history and the different religions; to teach you real skills, and art and music and sport.

A human is capable of thinking and working and leading by the age of thirteen, if only we had a system that allowed it. And if your teachers answer that you should just find someone else to do these things, pay a plumber, pay an electrician, hire an accountant, then something is wrong. What good is a school, an education, a teacher, that cannot help you meet the real problems of life? What are you going to that building for, over twenty years and more, and what future do you see in it, and what exactly are you paying for?

Parents, think hard about where you are sending your children, and go and meet the teachers and the boards and begin to ask these questions; surely you do not want your children coming out duller than they went in. And if you have grown too busy to question at all, you are already asleep. Wake up.

PART TWO · THE OUTER JOURNEY

Filter Needs, Wants & Desires

Needs are what you require to survive on the earth. Wants are stirred by your experiences and feelings, and, more than ever now, by social media, celebrity, comparison, and advertising; we want what we see others holding. Most of us are, to some degree, brainwashed by all of this, made restless by envy and imitation. Let me help you simplify it, choice by choice:

- go for local, organic, home-made, cultural food, not the factory-packed and the socially hyped;
- go for fresh air, not the boxed air of a polluted city;
- go for a peaceful setting, not the constant noise of people and machines;
- go for fresh, local water, not water bottled in plastic and shipped across the world;
- go for natural views and sounds and temperatures, not only what is man-made;

- go for knowledge and wisdom, not propaganda and manipulation;
- go for a supportive, progressive community, not a controlling or draining one;
- go for real travel and real cultures, not sightseeing and sponsored posts;
- go for self-reliance, independence, and freedom, not corporate control;
- go for the natural over the chemical and the processed. Go for the truth. Go for the roots.

These are what truly develop us into better beings, and what let us pass ourselves on, in a better form, to the generations that follow.

PART THREE

The Challenges

When the inner and the outer journeys are done, the next level begins: to take all of this out into the world, and live it. What follows are not daily tasks but larger challenges, for a life.

PART THREE • BEYOND THE JOURNEY

Design Your Own Challenges

After the journey, begin to travel, with as little money as you can, finding ways to get what you need without it, because money is the easy shortcut that narrows your ability to think and improvise. And travel as no one: let no one know where you came from, who your parents are, what you own, what you studied, or what you do. Just be no one. Ask far more about the people and the place and the culture than you tell about yourself.

Here are some hands-on, life-shifting challenges to grow into:

- Always keep a sense of past, present, and future, and of when and where to use each in life.
- Spend seven days in silent observation of the self; and go, once, early in life, to a vipassana retreat.
- Live for a time among Christians, Hindus, Muslims, Buddhists, Jews, without attaching yourself to any one belief; keep moving, keep exploring.

- Find places to volunteer, organic and permaculture farms, orphanages, schools, elder homes, workshops in carpentry, pottery, ironwork, mechanics, electricity, yoga, art, and craft, changing places often.
- Keep journals, of dreams, facts, food, emotions, plans, and time. Practise writing with either hand on alternating days, and in different languages, and with simple sketches.
- Recall your first memories, of self, family, love, hate, anger, fear, joy, sacrifice, and lost passions.
- Live one week without spending money, then one month, finding other ways, telling stories, exchanging time and skill and goods, to get what you need.
- Cook a meal made only of what the nature around you gives.
- Design your ideal twenty-four-hour rhythm, then live it, adjusting for each season, since every season moves the mood differently.
- Sleep in many different villages and farms and projects, at least a month in each. Do not pass through like a tourist; live the local way, and learn to see through local eyes.
- Draw your family tree, then design a regenerative version of it. Meet your relations; see who they are, how many you never knew, how many do not care.
- Design a multi-skilled way of earning for yourself, but do not let money be the motive; let the wish to explore and to succeed lead, and help others so that a community grows around you.

- Give your skill, for a day, to a stranger, a community, an orphanage, expecting nothing, without caring who receives it.
- Write one letter to your future child. Whether or not you ever send it does not matter. Ask yourself what you want to give them, what air and land and food and education, what example, what legacy, and do not write your expectations onto them; tell them, instead, to be free and independent.

THE RETURN

Returning to the World

So here we are, at the end. And I want to be clear about something, because it matters more than anything else in this book: this was never about running away from the world and never coming back.

For a few months you stepped back. You built a quiet space and learned to sit in it. You watched your breath and your thoughts. You cleaned out your body, your food, your skin, your senses. You filtered your kitchen, your clothes, your walls, the noise, the people, the endless wants. You did it alone, in silence, without a timer, without an audience. That was the whole point of stepping away, to see yourself and the world clearly, without all the covers on.

Now, go back. Go back to the modern world, all of it. Pick up the phone again. Play the music. Live in the city if you must. Eat what you want, meet who you want, work where you want. I am not asking you to give up the world. I never was. This journey was the detox, the cleaning, the seeing. Life is what comes after.

But you will be different now. You will use the phone instead of the phone using you. You will choose the music instead of the music choosing your mood. You will eat by what your body needs, keep the friends who are truly for you, and let the rest go without noise. You will see the past, the present, and the future, all three, and know when to stand in each.

This is the balance I want for you, and the balance this world needs: not nature against technology, not the old against the new, but a human who has met all three, nature, technology, and other humans, cleanly, and knows how to hold them in harmony. You cannot find that balance while you are still full of what the system poured into you. You had to empty out first. Now that you have, the world is yours to use well.

Do not treat this as a one-time challenge you passed and put on a shelf. Make it a way of living. Return to the space when you drift. Fast when you need to remember hunger. Filter again when the noise creeps back in, because it will. You will keep losing people, places, habits, even purposes you were sure of, and each time you will find you were only shedding what never truly mattered. That is not loss. That is you, becoming clear.

WRITE TO ME

And last, this. I am not a guru on a mountain. I am one human who walked this and wanted to share it. So if a question rises on the way, if something breaks open in you, if you finish and

want to tell someone, write to me. I will be glad to hear it, and glad to help. You can reach me through the Hunate pages. Do not be afraid to speak to another human. If you are, that fear is the first thing to work on.

Keep changing. Keep evolving. Welcome back.
Khem Raj Pradhan